



1,345

THE NUMBER OF OFFICERS AND CREW ABOARD THE SS NORMANDIE



BENITO MUSSOLINI (1883–1945)

Benito Mussolini imposed his authoritarian, militaristic rule on Italy from 1922 to 1943. His Fascist state was widely admired, but dreams of conquest led to military adventures and an alliance with Nazi Germany. Unwisely leading his country into World War II, he was deposed as the Allies invaded Italy in 1943 and eventually killed by partisans.

Roosevelt's original New Deal (see 1933), favoring labor unions over big business and the poor over the rich. The **Wagner Labor Relations Act** placed the government on the side of workers who went on strike to gain union rights. The **Social Security Act** provided federal pensions for the elderly and subsidies for state-run unemployment and sickness benefit schemes. Such measures, financed by higher taxes on the rich, were denounced as socialist by most US newspapers and their millionaire owners, but **confirmed Roosevelt's popularity** with the bulk of the American people.

In the **civil war** raging in **China**, communist guerrillas escaped destruction by the forces of Chiang Kai-shek's Nationalist government through a series of **strategic withdrawals** to remote areas of the north and west. During the **Long March** from Jiangxi to Shaanxi, a journey of around 6,200 miles (10,000 km),

Mao Zedong asserted himself as the foremost communist leader. In December 1935, Mao declared that the Long March had been "a manifesto, a propaganda force... proclaiming to the world that the



Long March survivors

Chinese communists of the First Front Army arrive at Yan'an in Shaanxi province at the end of the strategic retreat known as the Long March.

Red Army is an army of heroes." But for the time being these "heroes" remained hunted rebels.

In Germany, Hitler's Nazi regime formalized its anti-Semitism through the **Nuremberg Laws** in September. Jews were deprived of German citizenship and, by the **Law for the Protection of German Blood and German Honor**, marriage and extramarital sexual relations between Jews and non-Jews were banned. A problem in the application of **anti-Semitic legislation** was identifying to whom it applied, since Jewish Germans had been intermarrying with non-Jewish Germans for generations. The Nuremberg Laws formally defined a Jew as a person with three or four Jewish grandparents.

Worried by Hitler's plans to expand German forces, Britain and France sought to enrol Italian Fascist dictator **Benito Mussolini** as an ally against Germany. This policy was wrecked by Mussolini's imperialist ambitions in Africa. In October, troops from Italy's east African colonies, Eritrea and Italian Somaliland, **invaded** the independent African state of **Ethiopia**. Ethiopian Emperor **Haile Selassie** was able to raise a large army, and although his forces were poorly equipped, they put up stout resistance. Ethiopia was a member-state of the League of Nations (see 1919). The League denounced Italy as an aggressor and called for economic sanctions. The British and French governments concocted a peace plan that would have given

Luxury liner

The Normandie was the largest, fastest, and most luxurious of the liners plying the Atlantic. Its interior was a riot of Art Deco features.

Mussolini a large chunk of Ethiopian territory. When news of the deal leaked out, public opinion in the democracies was outraged. British foreign secretary Samuel **Hoare** and French prime minister **Pierre Laval** were forced to resign, economic sanctions against Italy went ahead, and **Mussolini** was **pushed into the arms of Hitler**.

Despite the continuing effects of the economic Depression and the world's grave political problems, there were many **signs of technological progress**. The Hoover Dam was the most spectacular of a series of dam projects that would provide electric power and irrigation for large areas of the US. For those who could afford it, **luxury travel**—stylish ocean liners and intercontinental air travel—**flourished**. For the masses who could not afford this kind of luxury, there was always the cinema. The movie *Top Hat* marked the peak of the Hollywood musical, Fred Astaire and Ginger Rogers transporting viewers into a magical world of wealth and glamour.

slanted bow and slim hull increased ship's speed

